

KB0001 — Password Reset & Account Unlock Procedures

Category: Identity & Access Management

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Owner: IT Help Desk

Overview

This article covers standard procedures for resetting user passwords and unlocking locked-out accounts across corporate systems including Active Directory (AD), SSO (Okta), VPN, and SaaS applications.

Symptoms

- User receives "Account locked" or "Too many failed attempts" error
 - User unable to login after password expiry
 - Password reset email not received
 - User locked out after device change or MFA reset
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Root Causes

1. **Failed login attempts exceeding threshold** — AD policy locks accounts after 5 consecutive failed logins within 30 minutes.
 2. **Expired password** — Corporate policy enforces 90-day password rotation.
 3. **MFA token mismatch** — Device change without updating MFA app leads to lockout.
 4. **Okta session token corruption** — Rare; caused by browser cache or simultaneous sessions.
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Resolution Steps

Step 1: Unlock Active Directory Account

```
# Check account status
Get-ADUser -Identity <username> -Properties LockedOut, PasswordExpired,
BadLogonCount

# Unlock account
Unlock-ADAccount -Identity <username>

# Force password reset on next login
Set-ADUser -Identity <username> -ChangePasswordAtLogon $true
```

Step 2: Reset Password via Okta Admin

1. Login to Okta Admin Console → Directory → People
2. Search for affected user
3. Click "Reset Password" → Send via Email or Temporary Password
4. If MFA needs reset: Security → Multifactor → Reset Factor

Step 3: Verify VPN Access

- After AD unlock, ensure Cisco AnyConnect re-authenticates
- If VPN profile is cached with old credentials, clear profile and reconnect

Step 4: Clear SSO Session Cache

```
# Okta session invalidation via API
curl -X DELETE https://<okta-domain>/api/v1/users/<userId>/sessions \
-H "Authorization: SSWS <api_token>"
```

Escalation

- If account cannot be unlocked after 2 attempts → Escalate to AD Admin team (Tier 3)
 - If Okta Admin Console returns 403 → Check admin role assignment
 - If user is a service account → Notify application owner before resetting
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Prevention

- Enable self-service password reset (SSPR) portal: <https://sspr.corp.internal>
 - Recommend users enroll 2+ MFA methods
 - Enable "Smart Lockout" in Azure AD to reduce false lockouts
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Related Articles

- KB0002 — MFA Enrollment and Troubleshooting
- KB0004 — Okta Integration Configuration